

As we move beyond the “what-ifs” of the past, let’s imagine what can be done now and moving forward. You have an opportunity *now* to do and become something you can be really proud of in the *next* fifteen years. Starting today, what will future-you be glad you invested your time, energy, and resources into?

Grateful and Growing

We have the freedom to manage our resources in a way that makes sense for us and the ability to spend on the things we love, not just save, save, save. For Jen and me, finding day-to-day satisfaction in our stuff, status, and situation has us leaning into what we’re good at. We’re also learning, expanding our knowledge and skills, and finding new things we love. And it’s these things that have provided longevity in our values-based spending lifestyle, not just a means to an end.

Of course, we’re not living in fields of peonies and sugarplums all day. We’re not perfect, and our lives are far from perfect. But when we are able to cultivate a mindset of gratitude, we find the long-term effects are contentment and satisfaction.

Gratitude is the practical implementation of contentment, and it’s what makes values-based living and spending sustainable.

Here’s another *Merriam-Webster* moment: to be grateful is to be “conscious of benefits received.” Meaning the things that have already happened or are currently happening. Gratitude does not, and seemingly is not, tied to the future. It’s right now.

When cultivating a mindset of gratitude, it’s important to focus on two things:

Acknowledging the good things you currently have within your status, situation, and stuff

Identifying the role others play in bringing goodness into your life

Hmm, it’s almost as if those simplifying and community building efforts are useful for curating this internal perspective (wink, wink).

To notice the good things and the quality people you have around you, it’s going to require looking. When we don’t look for things, we don’t find